



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "does free will explain all evil?" in white, bold, sans-serif font.

**does free
will explain
all evil?**

Here's what Richard Swinburne says about this:

Swinburne seems to be thinking that certain kinds of important human relationships depend on the ability to harm one another. Is that plausible?

If Swinburne is right, the “free will defense” should be called the

“free will and genuine responsibility defense.”

“It is good that the free choices of humans should include genuine responsibility for other humans, and that involves the opportunity to benefit or harm them. ... A world in which agents can benefit each other but not do each other harm is one where they have only very limited responsibility for each other. ... A God who gave agents only such limited responsibilities ... would have reserved for himself the all important choice of the kind of world it was to be, while simply allowing humans the minor choice of filling in the details.”

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God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good

the ability
to harm others
is a great good

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free
will explain
all evil?

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

But this addition to the free will defense gives rise to a puzzle. One way

to bring out the puzzle is to ask: Can God do evil?

The standard answer to this question is that God cannot; that God is

not just good, but necessarily good.

should be so important that we have the ability to bring about evil. If God

But suppose that this is right. This makes it mysterious what why it

does not have this ability, and God is morally perfect, why should it be so

the amount of suffering which it has caused.

important for us to have this ability? And it must be **very** important, given

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'freewill and genuine responsibility defense.'